Prufrock Moonworm: Adapting Proven TBM Technology for Rapid Lunar Subsurface Development

Debra Barr
FeedingHumanity / Symbiotic-plans Initiative

Introduction

Stable, radiation-shielded subsurface volume is a foundational requirement for sustained lunar presence. Habitats, infrastructure, lava-tube expansion, and polar volatile access all benefit from rapid creation of protected underground space. This abstract applies first-principles analysis to the problem of lunar tunneling and concludes that targeted adaptation of The Boring Company's Prufrock tunnel-boring machine (TBM) offers the fastest, lowest-risk path under Artemis-era constraints.

First-Principles Foundation

Core physical invariants of TBM operation remain unchanged: high thrust and torque applied to a rotating cutterhead fracture the substrate; spoil is removed; immediate lining and support are installed; continuous advance is maintained. Lunar environmental deltas that must be addressed are vacuum (no convective cooling, electrostatic and abrasive dust, cold-welding risk), 1/6 g (reduced traction and altered spoil behavior), highly abrasive and variable regolith, and strict mass/volume limits compatible with Starship delivery plus high autonomy and ISRU priority.

Heritage Advantage of Prufrock

The Prufrock series already demonstrates rapid electric modular tunneling with iterative performance gains and porpoising deployment. Proven Earth advance rates (target >1 mile per week), mature electric drives, segmented architecture, and a rapid-iteration development culture constitute a substantial head-start. Clean-sheet lunar TBM designs discard these accumulated lessons and therefore incur higher development risk, longer timelines, and greater cost.

Targeted Lunar Adaptations

Only the environmental deltas require engineering attention: sealed systems with radiative cooling and abrasion-resistant cutters; electrostatic dust mitigation; recalibrated thrust and sintered-regolith anchoring for low-g traction; integrated nuclear or solar power; real-time ISRU sintering or extrusion of tunnel linings (a lunar advantage unavailable on Earth); modular Starship-compatible delivery and robotic assembly; and exploitation of 1/6 g for mass handling. These modifications preserve the majority of existing intellectual property and hardware architecture.

Comparative Assessment

Relative to a clean-sheet lunar TBM, Prufrock adaptation yields medium rather than high development risk, a timeline measured in years of iteration rather than 5–10+ years of full R&D, substantially lower cost through 60–80 % IP reuse, higher confidence in advance-rate potential, and direct synergies with ISRU lining and autonomous robotics. Primary residual risks (dust, anchoring) are amenable to ground testing in vacuum chambers with lunar simulants.

Conclusion and Alignment with LSIC Goals

From first principles, modifying Prufrock is the decisive choice: it retains proven excavation physics and execution capability while addressing only the necessary environmental differences. The resulting Prufrock Moonworm concept enables faster creation of radiation-shielded subsurface volume and maps directly onto the LSIC Excavation and Construction focus area as well as supporting Crosscutting Capabilities in autonomy, ISRU, and surface infrastructure. Collaboration is sought for detailed adaptation studies, simulant testing, and ISRU lining integration.